

Rep. Tom Emmer on Squawk Box

CNBC

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HOST (JOE):

House Majority Whip Tom Emmer. It's good to see you, Congressman. Thanks for joining us in studio. I haven't heard of the lines in Houston. Are they down in lines at other places? Have we seen that situation get a lot better with the president paying the TSA? And I saw Democrats want to, I kid you not, they want to block Trump's ability to pay the TSA agents.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Yeah, makes a lot of sense, doesn't it? Well, it does if you're trying to, you know, if you want Americans to suffer because you're trying to, if you want to use it as leverage to get what they think they're going to get for ICE. Wrong kind of leverage. That's not the way you negotiate. You don't use, you don't negotiate with American's lives, their safety with American's enjoyment of life. You don't negotiate with that. In this case, you asked me if it's better. In some places, it's better. In other places, it's going to take a little bit of time. You've got an agency that because of the Democrats refusal, refusal to work with Republicans, the 43 day shutdown last fall. Now we've got a record shutdown on just Homeland Security. Joe, you realize this agency has not been paid for half the fiscal year. How do you stay in a job where you're not going to get a paycheck for half the year? So there are now some serious issues about retaining employees, attracting new employees. So yes, in some places, I mean, I talked to some of your staff when I came in, they went through LaGuardia yesterday in minutes.

HOST (JOE):

Yeah, I had no problem at LaGuardia. I had no problem in Omaha. I had no problem in Phoenix all in the last several days. And in fact, you know, kudos to the TSA agents who are there working. And I did see ICE agents in Phoenix, too. Thank you to all of them. But you guys have a bigger problem with these shutdowns, with the idea it's there. And I have to say, there's you feel a little concerned when you're traveling these days because you worry about what's happening with the air traffic controllers, too. How about how about when you work in Times Square with sleeper cells and DHS not not not funded? I don't want to give anyone any ideas, but this is the you know, any New York City venue is probably if there are if how many got in during the about 900 Iranians or something.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Look, the I don't think you can ever accurately tell what number it is because there was really no security at the southern border. We can talk about the ones that were actually picked up and released into the U.S. We can talk about the ones that were spotted coming into the U.S. But that will play with fire by not funding it.

HOST (JOE):

And but people don't know. I see people that are interviewed on on TV say all the Republicans, they've had all these chances to do it. They're playing games. They don't realize this is this is a simple government funding for an agency. It's the third biggest agency, isn't it?

REP. TOM EMMER:

It really is. And yes. And so they're trying to carve out ice and instead of just doing the normal funding of the agency. Joe, it started as carving out. Actually, it didn't. It started as a bicameral, bipartisan bill. Republicans, Democrats all agreed on the funding for homeland security. OK, then all of a sudden, Joe, Chuck Schumer did my thing with Chuck. Chuck Schumer suddenly reneged on the deal and said, no, and now we're not going to fund that. And it was all about ice. You know what they added on Thursday? They added customs and Border Patrol now. So it's not just ice. It's customs.

HOST (JOE):

Is there a way to stop this from happening forever? I mean, just the idea that either party can use this at some point.

REP. TOM EMMER:

I have an idea. OK, great. I'm in the house. My suggestion has been if you just refuse to get rid of the filibuster, you see, you can't get the you can't get the votes. I mean, forget for a second that the Democrats will get rid of it the instant they are in charge. But let's just let's just say for the sake of argument, you can't get rid of the filibuster. Yeah. Why can't you pass a rule to modify it? Much like Harry Reid did for district court judges. Why don't you pass a rule that modifies it? The filibuster is suspended if any part of government is not funded. So you can't use this as the ultimate leverage to stop whether you're Republican or Democrat. And by the way, as long as government isn't funded without that filibuster, you can pass anything with 50 plus one in the Senate. Imagine right now you got Homeland Homeland Security. You could pass Homeland Security. You could strap the Save America Act onto it, pass it with 50 plus one votes. And as soon as the government's funded, you got your filibuster back.

HOST (JOE):

Congressman, we thought that what was it? It was late at night. Did the Senate just they didn't vote. They just allowed a unanimous approval. So soon as Majority Leader Thune was there when that was happening. I didn't think Republicans in the House were going to block that. I thought they I thought they would be. I thought it would with the midterms coming up. I thought then it would they'd be afraid to do it. Little did I know that Mike Johnson was going to come out like Rambo or something on Friday. You were standing behind him and you were nodding. But look, look at this. Isn't this mad at Thune? Did he say this is not going to fly?

REP. TOM EMMER:

This this wasn't about John Thune. It's a bad look. As far as any Americans concerned, for senators to be flying out of town before the business is done and then passing a bill by unanimous consent. Right. And then, by the way, getting a lot of them, a lot of them getting escorted past the line and video of all of that, all bad optics. But the real issue for the House, which is why Mike Johnson had really no choice because our well, but our members, we can't vote for something that literally says zero dollars for Customs and Border Patrol, zero dollars for immigration and Customs Enforcement. You realize by not funding this, this is twenty five percent of ice. This would stop the investigations into stopping child exploitation, drug trafficking. This would affect cybersecurity. There are so many things that are day to day operations and people are forgetting a lot of the functions at Homeland Security are done by civilian employees. None of them are getting paid. So it's a big, big deal. And the other thing was a procedural thing. Think about it, Joe. Appropriations bills have give and take for both sides. That's why it was an agreement between Republicans and Democrats. You're going to get stuff you don't like. You're going to get stuff you do like. It should be predominantly the bill of the majority party. But you

make concessions. Guess what? If you can now pull out just items, whatever you want out of an appropriations bill, it's a terrible precedent for the House because maybe a transportation bill. Somebody is going to want to pull out funding for trains because they don't like trains. Maybe an ag bill. Somebody is going to want to pull out the nutrition section because they don't like SNAP benefits. I mean, this was a big issue in the House. And I think the White House has told us that they are going to be able to handle this through the recess while people are out of Washington, D.C., and when we come back, I think you'll see a quick effort by Republicans. If Democrats still refuse to put the safety of the American public first, you'll see a skinny reconciliation bill move very quickly.

HOST (JOE):

What about Senate and House? National Immigration and Customs Enforcement. Call it that. Nice. Every time that Democrats, especially, they have to say nice instead of vice. Have you thought, is that a, just bring that back with you and maybe, maybe.

REP. TOM EMMER:

I will. I will. And then we'll recruit Joe to run for Congress next time.

HOST (JOE):

What about the, what do you expect to hear from the president tonight?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I think the president's going to give us an update on the mission that is being conducted in Iran. It's amazing. 11,000 targets have been hit. 90% of the drones have been, the drone traffic is down by almost 100%. I think there's 10% left. This has been an incredibly successful mission, in spite of the tragedy of losing 13 of our service men and women. This is an amazing, amazing mission. And guess what? If you watch the news in this country, you'd think we were losing. We are being very successful, and I expect him to give us a timeline that it's going to be done very soon.

HOST (JOE):

Are two of the objectives, you think, would one be to find that enriched uranium? Is that on the list, and do you think it should be? And second of all, should reopening the Strait of Hormuz be on the list, or is it fine to leave with that still closed?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I mean, it's, let's just, the mission was an imminent threat. And the Iranians, within two weeks before this mission started, were claiming they did not have any long-range capacity. And as we have already seen, because during the conflict, they rolled out a couple of ballistic missiles in an attempt to attack an American military base that could hit Western Europe, could hit London. So clearly, this is a very serious threat. That's the mission, is to end that threat.

HOST (JOE):

But again, the enriched uranium, that's a much tougher task, and it's one that people are worried about.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, the regime, in my opinion, is just a member of Congress. The regime has to go. The bigger question that you're asking, Becky, by the way, the other thing that our media does not report, is there are pro-Trump rallies all around the world by Iranians who have been excommunicated from Iran. They are, the Iranian people are thrilled that this is happening, but nobody wants to report that either. Why? Because Trump is doing it. That's the only reason.

HOST (JOE):

But again, enriched uranium, should we go after that, and should we make sure we stay until the Strait of Hormuz is closed?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I think to be consistent with what the president has said, and he's always been consistent, they will never have a nuclear weapon, which means they are not going to possess enriched uranium that they can make weapons.

HOST (JOE):

And the Strait of Hormuz? Is that our job, or the rest of the world's?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I think the rest of the world better get involved, because this is a collective issue. And again, it's amazing that Western Europe, America's energy rich. Western Europe, they need that Strait open.

HOST (JOE):

All right, Congressman, thank you. Majority Whip Tom Emmer. When do you go back?

REP. TOM EMMER:

We go back a week from Monday.

HOST (JOE):

Good God. All right. Thank you.

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